The angle between the tangent to the liquid surface at the point of contact and the solid surface inside the liquid is known as the *angle of contact between the solid and the liquid*. It is denoted by θ.

Its value is different at interfaces of different pairs of solids and liquids. In fact, it is the factor which decides whether a liquid will spread on the surface of a chosen solid or it will form droplets on it.

Let us consider three interfaces such as liquid-air, solid-air and solid-liquid with reference to the point of contact 'O' and the interfacial surface tension forces T_{sa}, T_{sl} and T_{la} on the respective interfaces as shown in Figure 7.26.

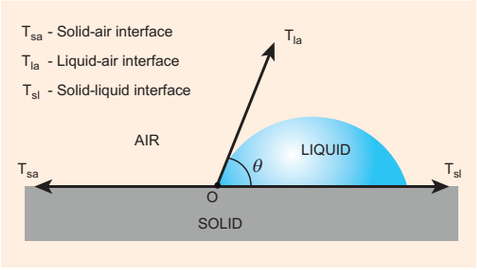


Figure 7.26 Angle of contact of a liquid

Since the liquid is stable under equilibrium, the surface tension forces between the three interfaces must also be in equilibrium. Therefore,

$$T_{sa} = T_{la}\cos\theta + T_{sl} \Rightarrow \cos\theta = \frac{T_{sa} - T_{sl}}{T_{la}} \quad (7.29)$$

From the above equation, there are three different possibilities which can be discussed as follows.

(i) If $T_{sa} > T_{sl}$ and $T_{sa} - T_{sl} > 0$ (water-plastic interface), then the angle of contact θ is acute angle (θ less than 90°) as cosθ is positive.

(ii) If $T_{sa} < T_{sl}$ and $T_{sa} - T_{sl} < 0$ (water-leaf interface), then the angle of contact is obtuse angle (θ less than 180°) as cosθ is negative.

(iii) If $T_{sa} > T_{la} + T_{sl}$, then there will be no equilibrium and liquid will spread over the solid.

Therefore, the concept of *angle of contact* between the solid-liquid interface leads to some practical applications in real life. For example, soaps and detergents are wetting agents. When they are added to an aqueous solution, they will try to minimize the angle of contact and in turn penetrate well in the cloths and remove the dirt. On the other hand, water proofing paints are coated on the outer side of the building so that it will enhance the angle of contact between the water and the painted surface during the rainfall.

7.5.5 Excess of pressure inside a liquid drop, a soap bubble, and an air bubble

As it is discussed earlier, the free surface of a liquid becomes curved when it has contact with a solid. Depending upon the nature of liquid-air or liquid-gas interface, the magnitude of interfacial surface tension varies. In other words, as a consequence of surface tension, the above such interfaces have energy and for a given volume, the surface will have a minimum energy with least area. Due to this reason, the liquid drop becomes spherical (for a smaller radius).

When the free surface of the liquid is curved, there is a difference in pressure between the inner and outer the side of the surface (Figure 7.27).

i) When the liquid surface is plane, the forces due to surface tension (*T, T*) act tangentially to the liquid surface in

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